MODULE 3
The Problem Space
Fall in Love with the Problem, Not the Solution

ASSIGNMENT: 5 hair-on-fire interviews + Pain Map & JTBD statement

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Check-In:

How many users did you talk to?

Check-In:

How much new revenue did you sign?

Today

Check-in & interview debrief — what did 5 humans actually say? (15')

IDEA 1 · Fall in love with the problem, not your solution (10')

IDEA 2 · Jobs-to-be-Done — what they'd hire you for (10')

IDEA 3 · The Mom Test, properly — reading what came back (15')

IDEA 4 · Hair-on-fire segments — and who actually pays (10')

Case · Personio: listening to Munich's HR managers (30')

Workshop · Pain Mining (90')

Wrap-up · pain map + JTBD + target segment (5')

Recap from last time

Show us where you‘re at in 3 Minutes or less!

What did you do?	What did you learn?	How can we help?

Make it credible:

1. Facts: Statistics or Research: What do they say? What does it mean? Where are they from?
2. Numbers: Usage or Surveys: How were they reported? How did they change? Why is it relevant?
3. Quotes: Interviews or Testimonials: What did they say? Why did they say it? What could this mean?
4. Images: Screenshots or Users: What happened? What changed? Why is it relevant?

IDEA 1: Fall in love with the problem

Solutions age fast. Problems are durable — a real one will still be there after your third pivot.

Your idea from last week is a problem HYPOTHESIS. This week we find out how deep the pain really goes.

Framing the problem space

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Lean Startup: Problem oriented approach

Solution oriented:



- I developed this great product.



- I love it.
- Everybody will love it.
- Because I love it.
- My next version will be made from aluminum.

Problem oriented:

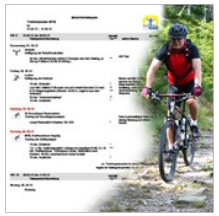


Work pressure – lack of balance

Technologies



Organization



Products





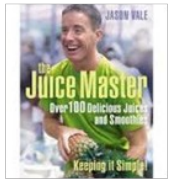
Services



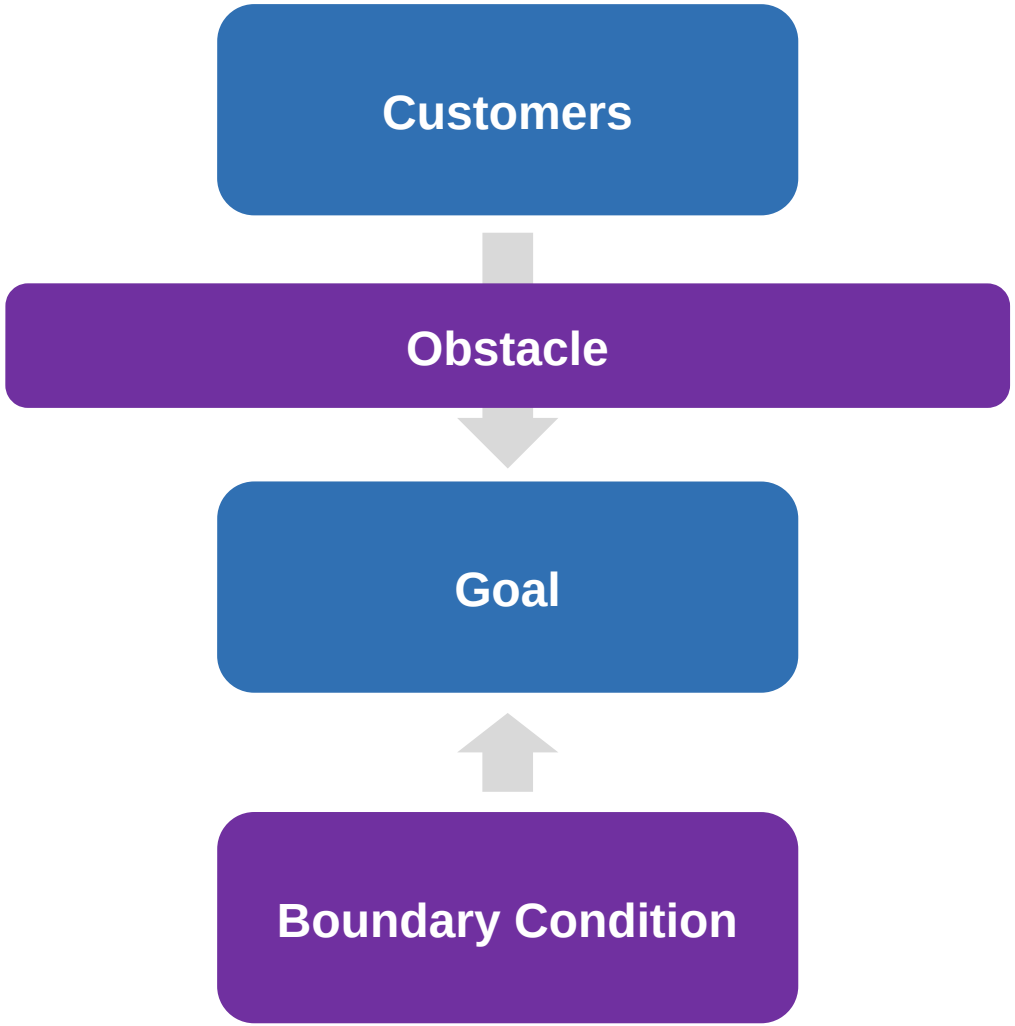
Bundles

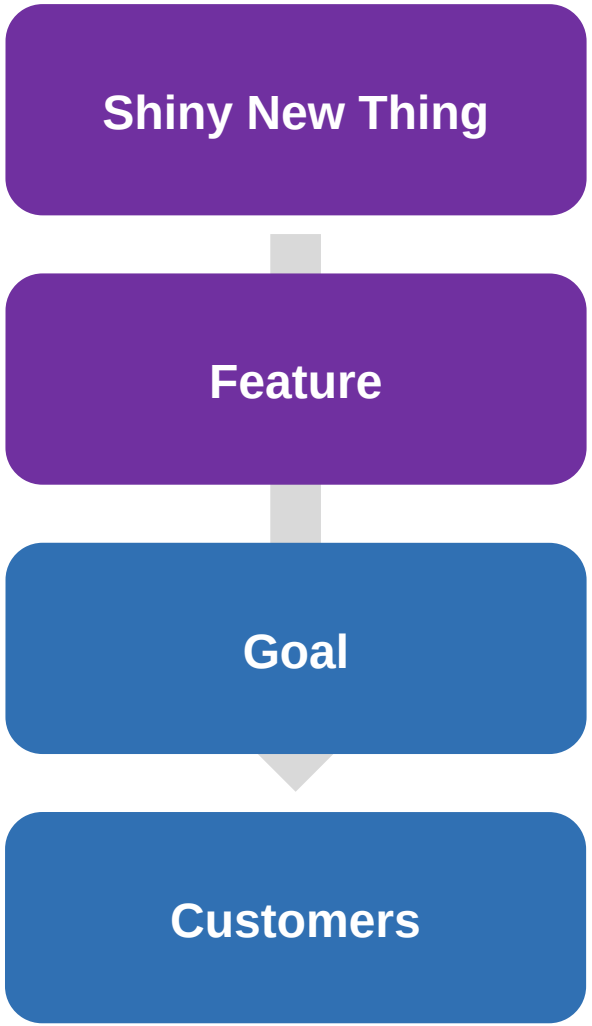


Education

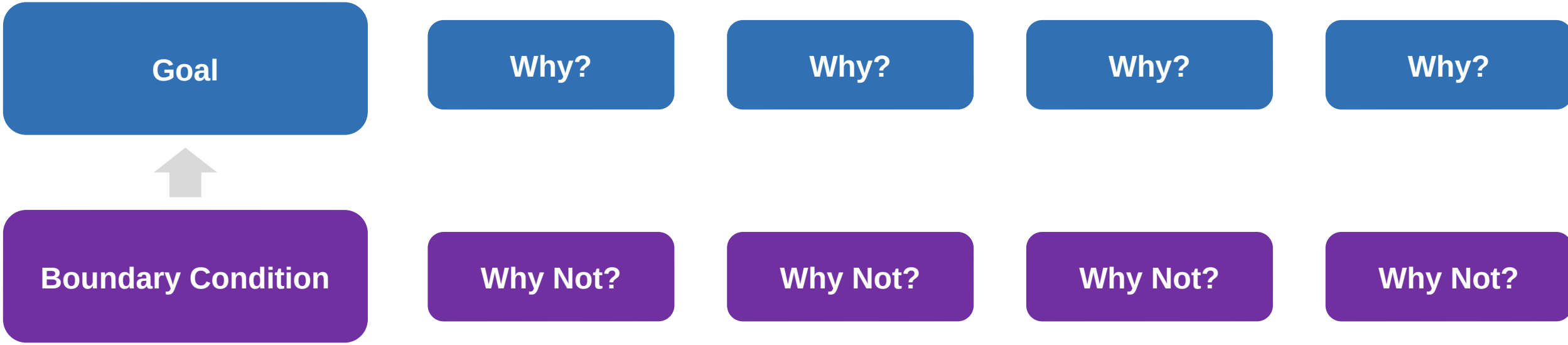


Problem Space vs. Solution Space





Finding root causes



"*The best startups generally come from founders having a personal experience with a problem.*"

— Paul Graham, Y Combinator

Research confirms: 42% of startups fail because there's no market need. The problem wasn't validated. (CB Insights, 2023)

"The faster you find out you're wrong, the faster you find what's right."

— Lean Startup Principle

This week: 5 focused discovery interviews. Your goal is NOT to prove yourself right. It's to learn what's TRUE.

IDEA 2: Jobs-to-be-Done

Nobody wants your product. They want progress: when [situation], I want to [motivation], so I can [outcome].

Personio's customers didn't want 'HR software' — they wanted to stop drowning in Excel every Friday.

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JTBD STATEMENT

Construct Your Job Statement

VENTURE LABS

When I...

SITUATION

Describe the specific trigger moment or context

→

I want to...

MOTIVATION

State the goal or desired progress

→

So I can...

OUTCOME

Articulate the expected result (functional + emotional)

✗ **BAD**

"When I need to be productive..."

✓ **GOOD**

"When I sit down Monday morning with 47 unread emails..."

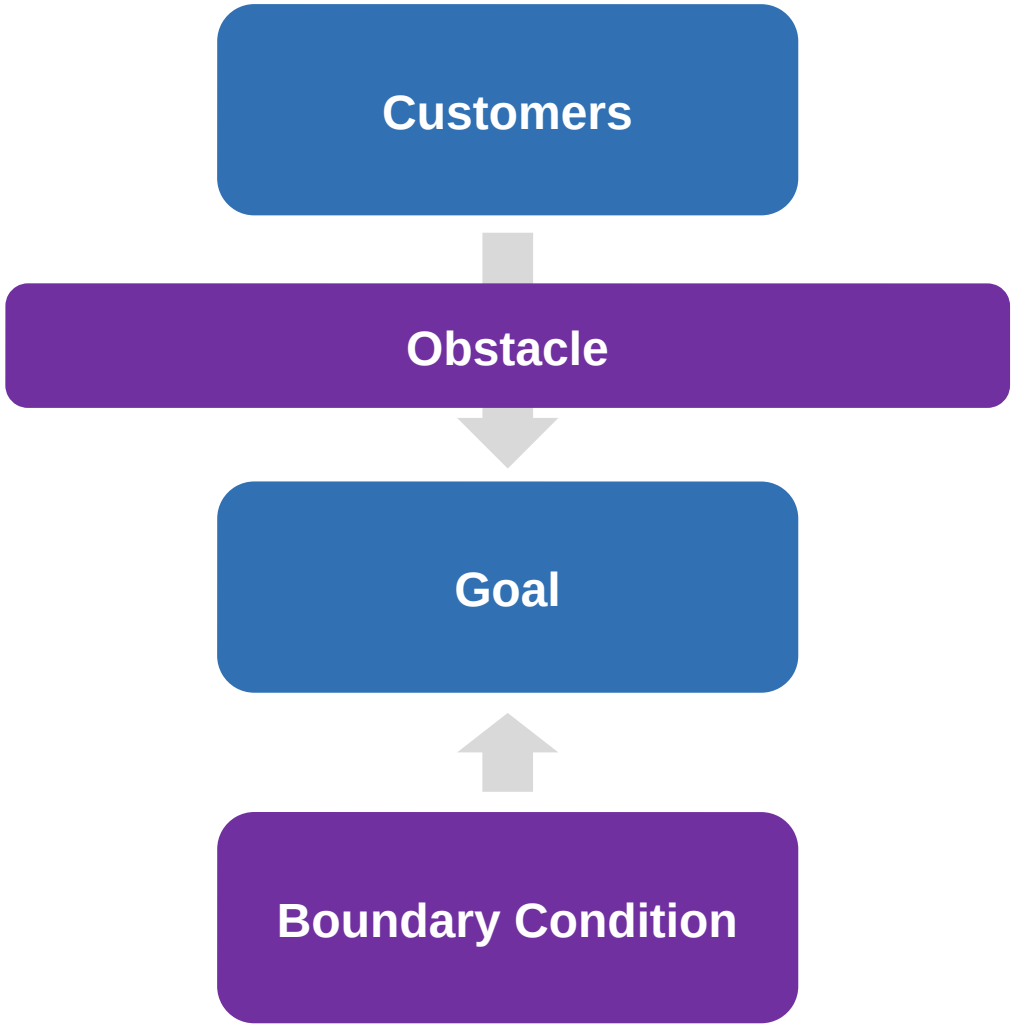
Ways of thinking about problems

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Skills to develop for the Problem Space

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What you should have an idea about by now



Who are you addressing for and why?

What hinders them from solving their problem?

Why is a solution desirable for them?

What other factor need to be considered?

IDEA 3: The Mom Test, properly

Last week: the five rules. This week: question craft, the 15-minute script, and reading signals in what came back.

The interview isn't the product. The verbatim quote in your Toolkit is.

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Good Questions vs. Bad Questions

✗ BAD QUESTIONS	✓ GOOD QUESTIONS
"Would you use this product?"	*"Tell me about the last time you faced this problem."*
"Do you think it's a good idea?"	*"What have you already tried to solve it?"*
"How much would you pay for this?"	*"How much did you spend on that solution?"*
"Would this solve your problem?"	*"What made you switch from X to Y?"*
Any question about the future ("would", "will")	*Questions about past behavior and real actions*

The Mom Test

Rob Fitzpatrick — Rules for customer conversations

1. **Talk about their life, not your idea**
   Get them to tell you about specific past behaviors, not hypothetical futures

2. **Ask about specifics in the past**
   "Tell me about the last time..." not "Would you ever..."

3. **Talk less, listen more**
   They should be talking 80%+ of the time. Your job is to learn.

"If you ask someone if they'd buy your thing, they'll almost always say yes." — Rob Fitzpatrick

Good vs. Bad Questions

BAD (Leading / Hypothetical)	GOOD (Past behavior)
"Would you use this?"	*"Tell me about the last time..."*
"Would you pay $X for...?"	*"What did you pay for...?"*
"Do you think this is a good idea?"	*"What have you tried to solve this?"*
"Don't you hate when...?"	*"What's hardest about...?"*

Power Questions: "What's the hardest part about X?" • "How are you dealing with X today?" • "Why haven't you solved this already?"

The 15-Minute Interview Script

0-2 min	**Warm-up**	Small talk, thank them for time, explain it's research (not sales)
2-5 min	**Context**	"Tell me about your role..." • "Walk me through a typical day..."
5-10 min	**Problem Deep-Dive**	"What's the hardest part about X?" • "Tell me about the last time..."
10-13 min	**Current Solutions**	"How are you solving this today?" • "What have you tried?"
13-15 min	**Wrap-up**	"Who else should I talk to?" • "Can I follow up?"

Pro tip: Record with permission. Use Otter.ai or Fireflies for transcription.

Reading the Signals

What they say vs. what it means

STRONG	MEDIUM	WEAK
• They describe specific pain in detail	• They acknowledge the problem exists	• "Yeah, that sounds cool"
• They've spent money/time trying to solve it	• They say "that would be nice"	• "I could see someone using that"
• They ask when they can buy it	• No current solution attempts	• Polite but vague responses

Rule of thumb: 5 strong signals > 50 medium signals

VALIDATION LEVELS

Hierarchy of Evidence

5	**Repeat Usage & Referrals**	*Users come back and bring others*	**Product-market fit**
4	**Payment**	*"Here's my credit card"*	**Strong signal**
3	**Commitment**	*"I'll try it / give you my email"*	**Medium signal**
2	**Interest**	*"Tell me more when it's ready"*	**Weak signal**
1	**Opinions**	*"I think this would be useful"*	**Worthless**

Your goal this week: Get to Level 3+ with at least 5 potential customers.

IDEA 4: Hair-on-fire — and who pays

Not all pain is equal. Find the segment where the problem is urgent, frequent, and already costing money.

Then the column most teams forget: BUDGET. Who feels the pain vs. who signs — if your segment can't pay, it's a hobby.

Hair-on-fire segmentation

For every problem, somebody has it worst. Find them:

- FREQUENCY — how often does it bite? (daily beats yearly)
- INTENSITY — what does one incident cost in time, money, stress?
- CURRENT SPEND — what are they already paying for workarounds? (receipts beat adjectives)
- BUDGET AUTHORITY — can this person say yes to €300, or must someone else? Add the column to your Pain Map today.

The 2am test: would anyone in this segment text you at 2am about it? That's hair-on-fire.

Your tiny segment is the moonshot's first step

Module 1 demanded a bold vision. Today demanded one hair-on-fire segment. Same strategy, two zoom levels.

The segment is where the vision touches the ground first — the wedge in the wall.

Personio: 'the HR operating system for Europe's SMBs' STARTED as 'Munich companies, 10–50 people, drowning in Excel'.

If your segment feels embarrassingly small, you're probably doing it right.

What are characteristics of an interesting painpoint?

Frequent & Recurring
Customers experience the pain regularly, not just occasionally.

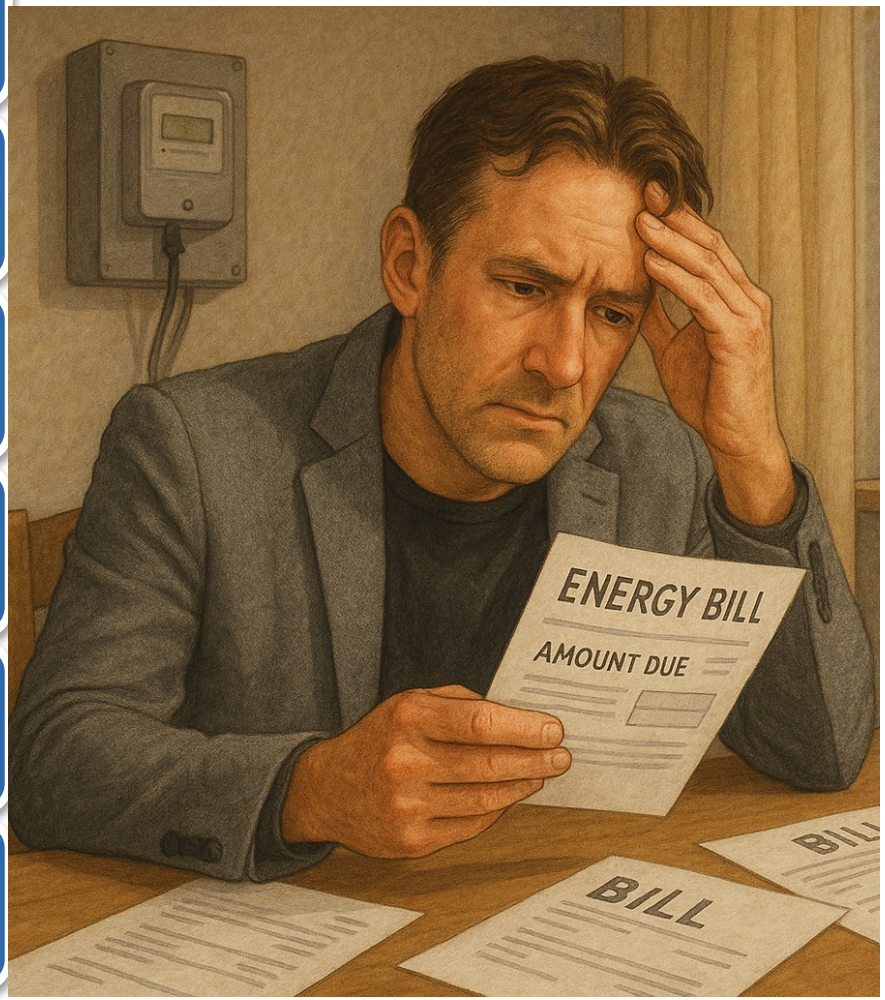
Costly or Risky
The pain has financial, emotional, or operational consequences if unresolved.

Clear & Specific
The pain can be described in simple terms by real users — not vague or abstract.

Felt by a Real Segment
A defined group of people or businesses is actively affected by it (identifiable customer persona).

Monetizable
Solving the pain is valuable enough that customers would pay for a better solution.

Aligned with Founder Insight
Ideally something the founder understands deeply (founder-problem fit).



Find relevant metrics to judge:

Problem Severity: How painful is this problem?

1 = Mild annoyance → 5 = Hair on fire

Market Size: How many people have this problem?

1 = Niche (<1K) → 5 = Mass market (>1M)

Founder-Fit: Do you understand this deeply?

1 = Outsider → 5 = Domain expert

Buildability: Can you ship in 4 weeks?

1 = Needs PhD team → 5 = Weekend project with AI

Total ≥ 16? Worth exploring further.

Real validation comes through the credit card

To validate your problem & solution:

Get signups

Get active users

Get paying customers

Interviewees Become Your First Customers

Why these 5 conversations matter far beyond this week

M3 · THIS WEEK

5 hair-on-fire interviews + exact customer language captured

→

M4 · NEXT WEEK

Their words become your landing page — they become your first leads

→

M5–8 · BUILD

Leads become prototype testers, then first active users

→

M9+ · REVENUE

Users become your first paying customers — validation that can't lie

End every interview with: “May I show you what we build?” — that yes is the seed of your customer list.

What the evidence says

42% of failed startups name 'no market need' as the killer — the single biggest cause (CB Insights post-mortems; practitioner data, honest label).

Jobs-to-be-Done: customers 'hire' products to make progress in a situation (Christensen et al., HBS) — it's why feature lists don't predict purchases.

Founders who personally lived the problem hold an information advantage — lead users see needs early (von Hippel 1986).

Your stack so far: noticed idea (M02) → JTBD framing → Mom Test evidence → hair-on-fire focus (today).

END RECAP — today in four lines

1 · The problem is the asset — your solution is just this week's guess

2 · JTBD: when [situation], I want [motivation], so I can [outcome]

3 · Mom Test depth: craft questions, script 15 minutes, read the signals

4 · Hair-on-fire + budget authority — aim where pain and money meet

This week: 5 interviews IN that segment, recorded, names + quotes in the Toolkit.

→ **Next week (Validating Problems): your interviewees' exact words become the landing-page headline; your segment becomes its traffic.**

Workshop: Pain Mining (90 min)

Agenda lives in M03_Workshop_Pain-Mining.md. Thin on interviews? You'll run 2 live calls in-session — no spectators.

Must produce: Pain Map (with budget column) + JTBD statement + hair-on-fire segment named.

Kill criteria: nobody in your interviews described spending money — time or euros — on the problem.

Wrapup & Checkout

This week — M03_Homework.md

1. Define the JTBD for your problem space
2. Test and iterate with at least 7 real interactions per week
3. Decide on the validation you are looking for and set up channels
4. Publish what you are working on and monitor the interest

Thank You!

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APPENDIX — original slides (49 restored as images)

These pages from the pre-rework deck are not in the current flow. Source snapshot: Instructor/original-decks/M03_Lecture_ORIGINAL.pdf.

Mark each: KEEP (design pass rebuilds it properly, editable) or KILL. Nothing gets deleted without your call.

Check-In:

What is your Energy Level Today?

Check-In:

What was your most exciting finding?

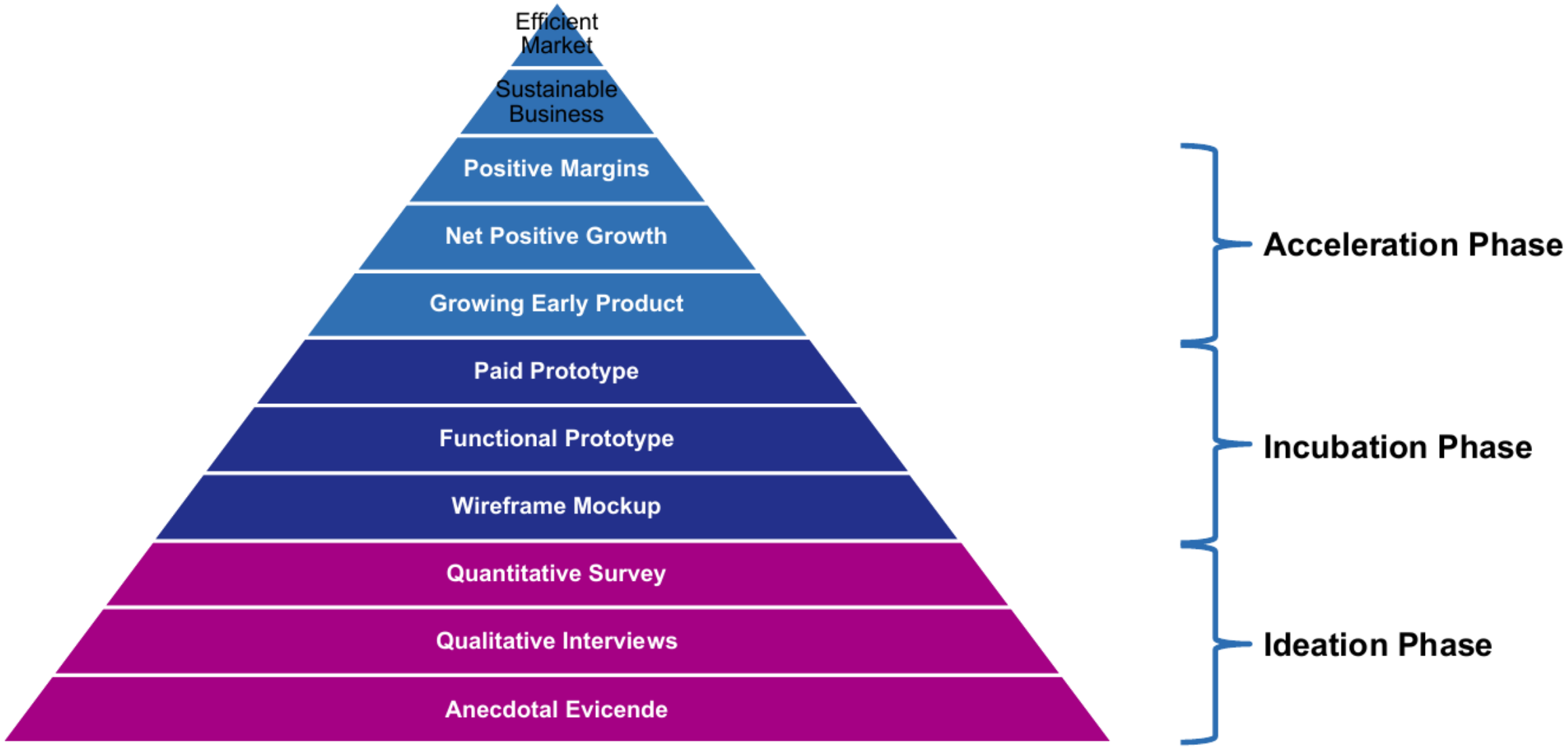
Check-In:

What was your biggest frustration?

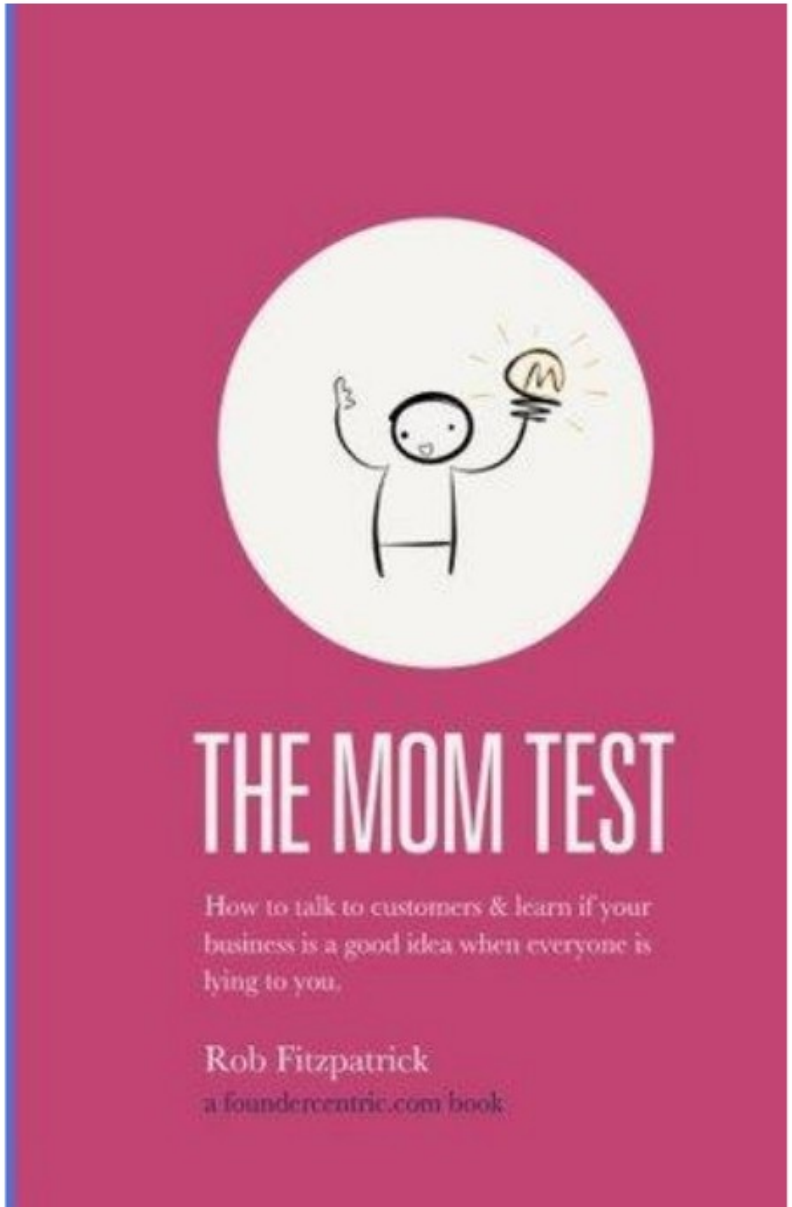
A Tier-List of Startup Ideas

S (Moonshots)	
A (Unsexy Plumbing)	Complience automation for SMEs; Invoice Reconciliation
B (Crowded Trades)	AI Project Management Tool; Improving knowledge management; Ed-Tech platform for universities
C (Wrapper Zone)	Chat with your files; GPT Cover Letter Generator; AI Meal Planner
D (Tarpit Ideas)	Apps to help you find places in new cities; Fitness trackers & Health apps; Social media for nieche audience; Language Learning App but with AI
F	Fridge Inventory App; Uber for dog walking

Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup



A reference to have in mind



Core principles:

- It is about getting information instead of confirmation
- A customer interview is not a sales pitch
- Ask questions about the past instead of the future
- Phrases such as ‘could you’ of ‘would you’ should be avoided
- Ask for specific examples

Great questions to ask

- What’s the hardest part about ….
- Tell me about the last time you encountered that problem…
- Why was this hard?....
- How have you tried to solve this problem?....
- What do you not love about the solutions that you have tried?...

Your Presentations

Challenge for startups: They tend to think in solutions but have to find a problem

Solution:

Autonomous robot that removes trash from the ocean

↓

Most of the trash in the ocean comes from rivers

↓

Most waste enters rivers in densely populated areas

↓

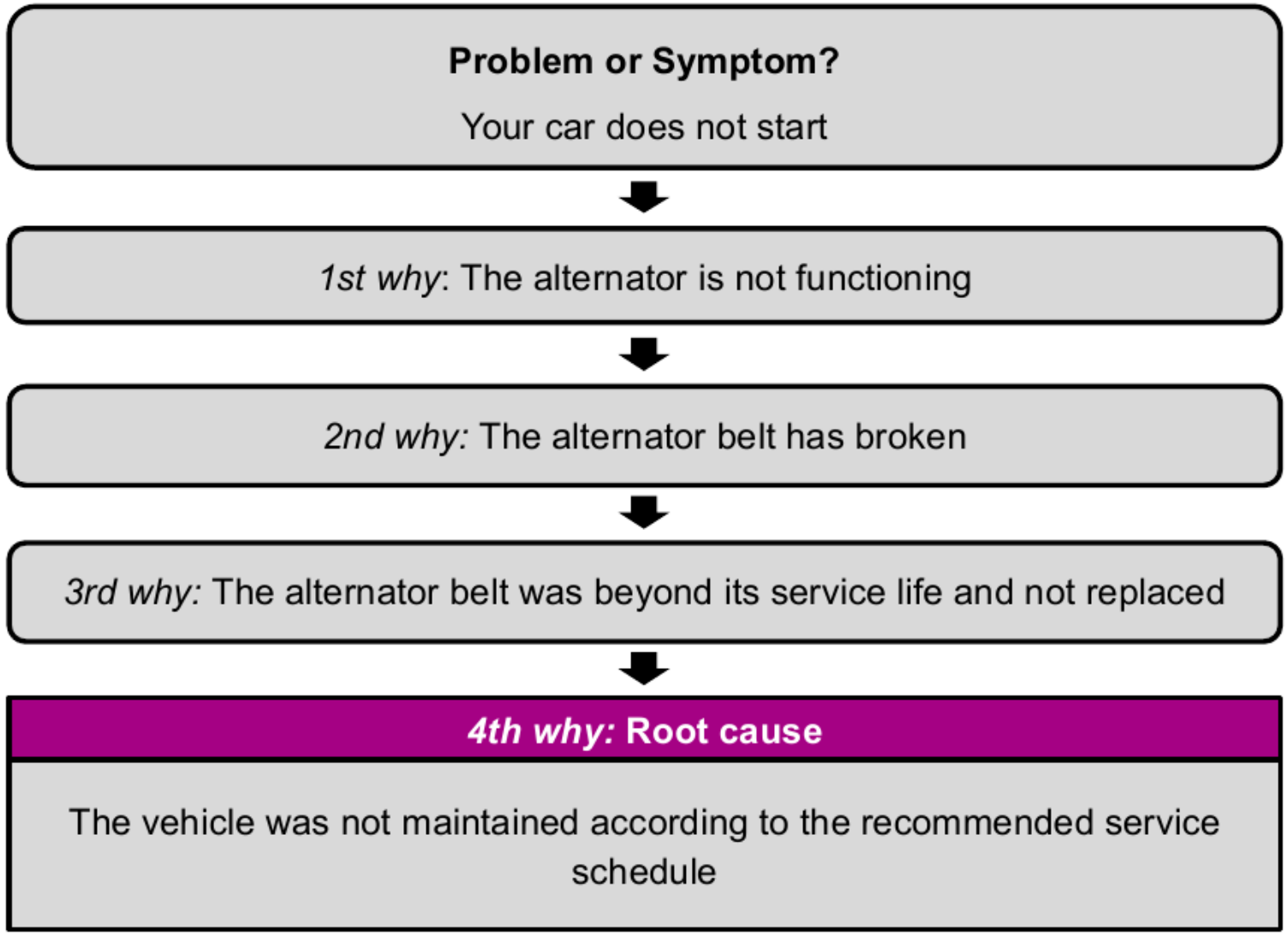
Particularly in densely populated areas in certain regions of the world

↓

Associated problems

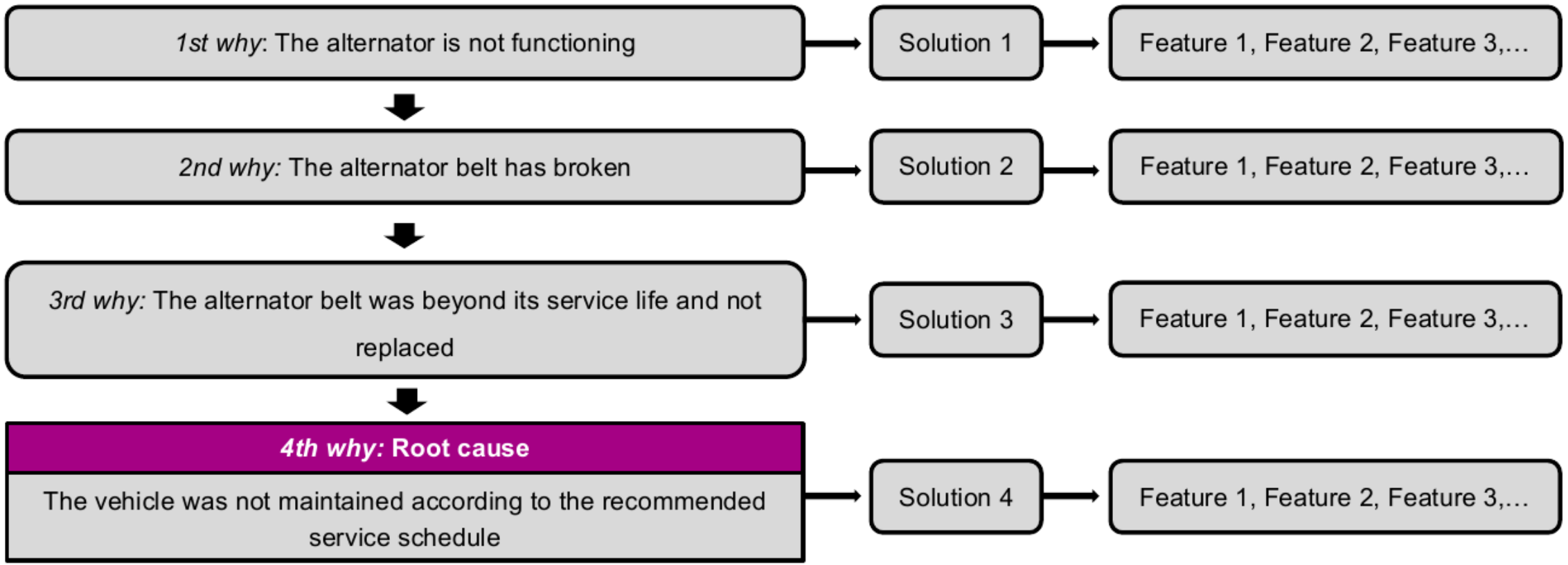
- People's awareness
- Companies produce plastic because it is cheaper than alternatives
- …

Challenge for startups: Find the root cause - don't build solutions for symptoms



A clear understanding of the root cause makes it easier to build a prototype that demonstrates your core value proposition

? There are always options for many solutions and features, but **which feature to start with?**



Finding a Problem

1. Turn off the filter for looking for startup ideas:
•**Reasoning**: Actively trying to think of startup ideas often filters out good ones because it constrains thinking to conventional areas.
•**Application**: Engage in daily activities with an open mind and without the pressure of 'finding an idea.'

2. Live in the future and build what seems interesting:
•**Reasoning**: Living at the cutting edge and focusing on emerging technologies or changes in society can naturally lead to spotting opportunities that others might overlook.
•**Application**: Stay updated with the latest technology, societal trends, and potential shifts in user behavior.

3. Scratch your own itch:
•**Reasoning**: Ideas built to solve the founder's personal problems are more likely to be valuable as they are real and tangible issues.
•**Application**: Reflect on personal annoyances or tasks that seem inefficient and think about how they could be improved.

4. Keep an eye on growing fields but avoid crowded areas:
•**Reasoning**: Emerging fields often have many unexplored niches but chasing trends can lead to crowded spaces with high competition.
•**Application**: Investigate new industries and technologies to find unique intersections or underserved markets.

5. Work on problems that interest you and are important:
•**Reasoning**: The intersection of passion and significance often yields the most persistent and insightful work.
•**Application**: Identify issues you care about that also have broader implications or market needs.

6. Notice things that seem to be missing:
•**Reasoning**: Sometimes the absence of a solution is itself an indicator of a problem space that is not adequately addressed.
•**Application**: Be observant about what tasks could be easier or what products/services could fill a gap in your own life.

Generate (no judgment)

Rules for divergent thinking:

- Quantity over quality — aim for 20+ ideas
- No criticism — every idea is valid
- Wild ideas welcome — impossible today ≠ impossible forever
- Build on others — "Yes, and..." not "No, but..."
- One conversation — no side discussions

Techniques:

- Brainstorming (classic)
- Crazy 8s (rapid sketching)
- SCAMPER (modify existing solutions)
- Reverse brainstorming (how to make it worse?)

Select (with criteria)

Desirability: Do people want this?

→ Evidence: Would they pay? Have they tried workarounds?

Feasibility: Can we build this?

→ With our skills, in 12 weeks, using AI tools?

Viability: Can this be a business?

→ Big enough market? Path to revenue?

Timing: Why now?

→ What changed that makes this possible today?

FRAMEWORK

Jobs-to-be-Done: "Hire" Products

> People don't buy products. They **HIRE** products to do a job.

⚙ Functional

What the product literally does for me

♥ Emotional

How it makes me feel

👥 Social

How others see me when I use it

The Drill Example

"I need a drill"

Surface request

→

"I need a hole"

Functional job

→

"I want to hang a picture"

Real goal

→

"I want to feel at home"

Emotional job

Christensen, C. (2016). Competing Against Luck. Harper Business.

VALUE PROPOSITION CANVAS

Map Customer Pains & Gains

VENTURE LABS

PAINS — What frustrates them	GAINS — What delights them
✗ Undesired outcomes they want to avoid	✓ Outcomes that would make them successful
✗ Obstacles blocking their progress	✓ Functional benefits they expect
✗ Risks they're afraid of	✓ Emotional benefits they desire
✗ Current solutions that suck	✓ Social benefits (status, belonging)
✗ Emotional pains: frustration, embarrassment, fear	✓ 10x improvement they'd pay for

ASSESSMENT

F.I.T. Framework: Is This Worth Solving?

VENTURE LABS

F — FREQUENCY

How often does this problem occur?

1 2 3 4 **5**

1 = yearly — 5 = daily

I — INTENSITY

How painful is it when it happens?

1 2 3 4 **5**

1 = minor annoyance — 5 = hair on fire

T — TREND

Is this problem growing or shrinking?

1 2 3 4 **5**

1 = declining — 5 = exploding

12–15: Full speed ahead

8–11: Dig deeper

< 8: Reconsider

Validation without Money

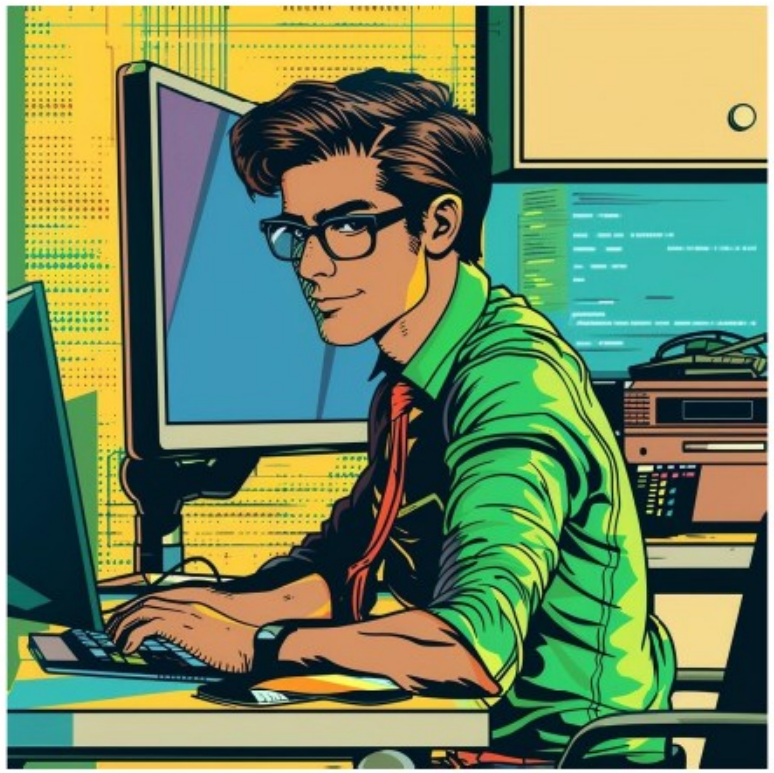
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"Every company is a tech company at scale."

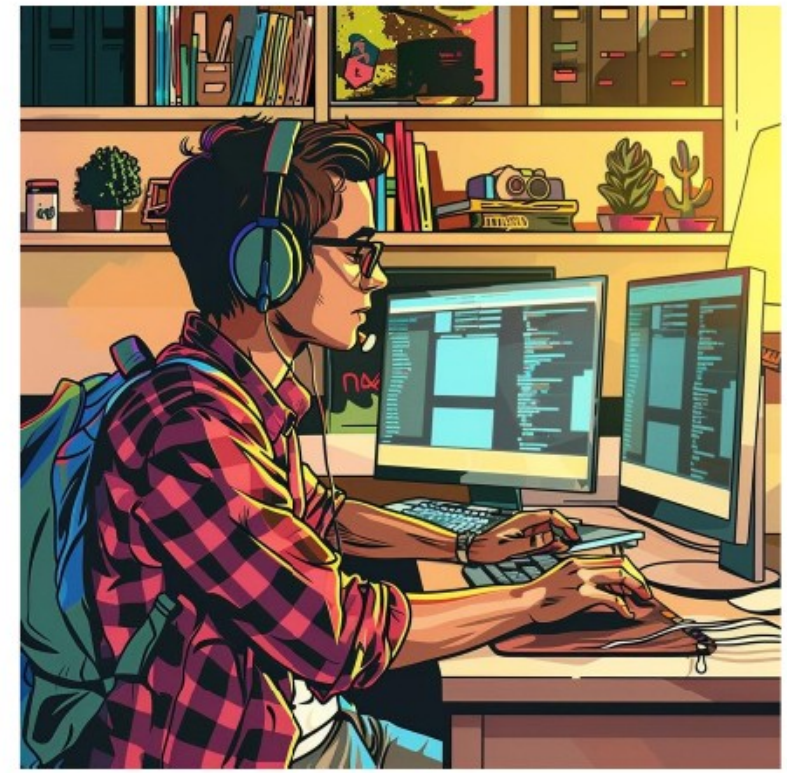
— Venture Sprint

This week: Starting out is NOT a tech job, it‘s simple people to people interaction.

Prototyping: Build your own Web-Store

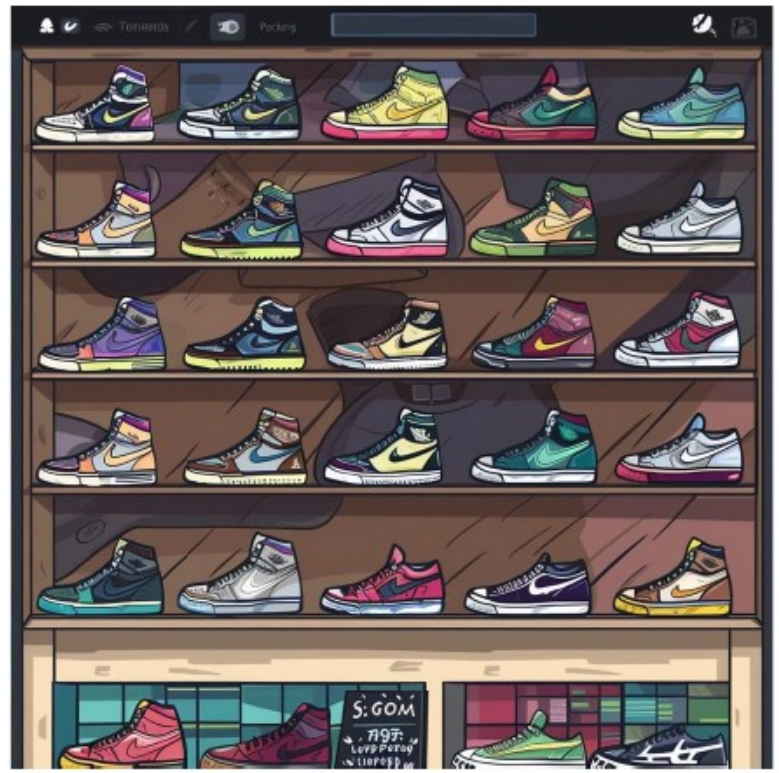






Prototyping: Build your own Web-Store

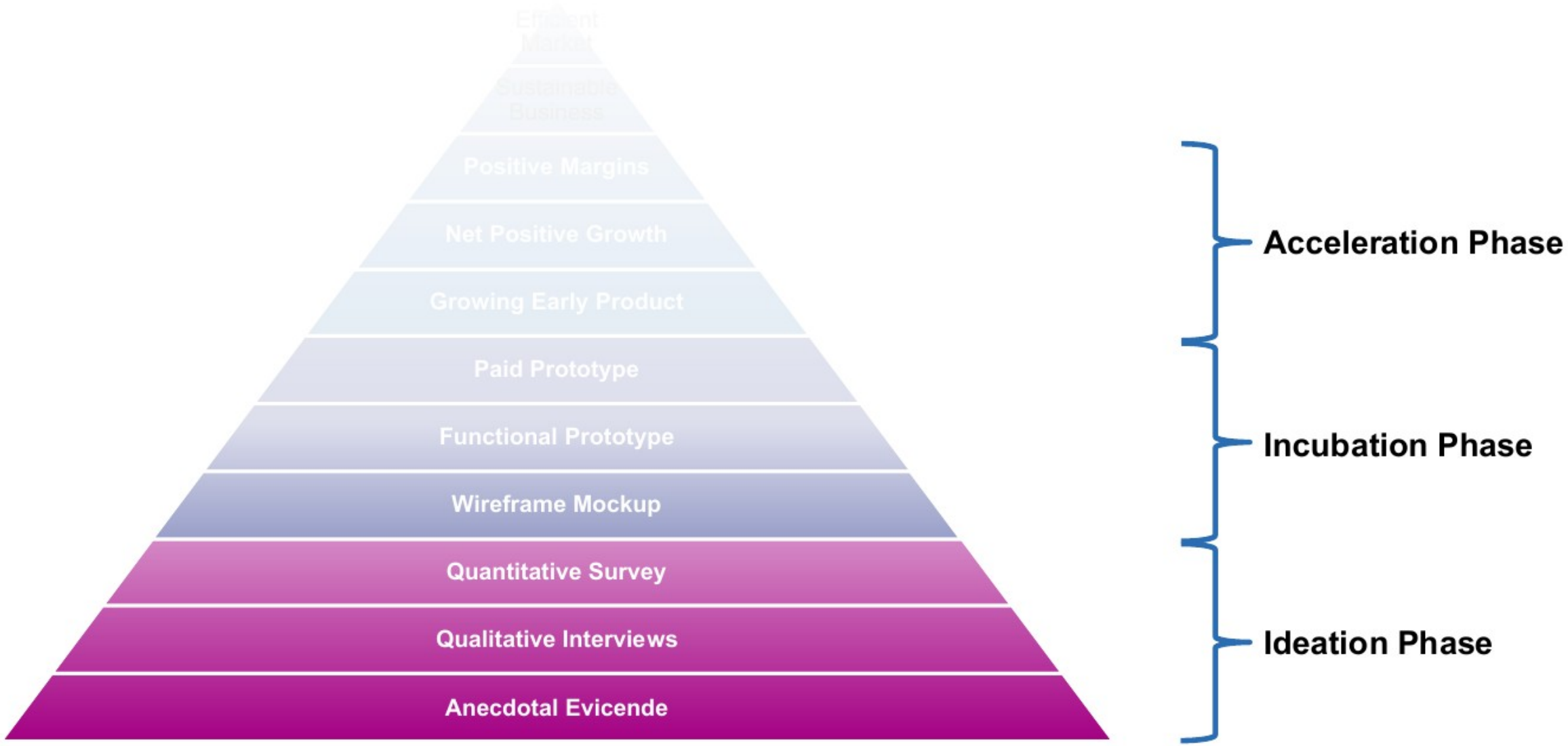




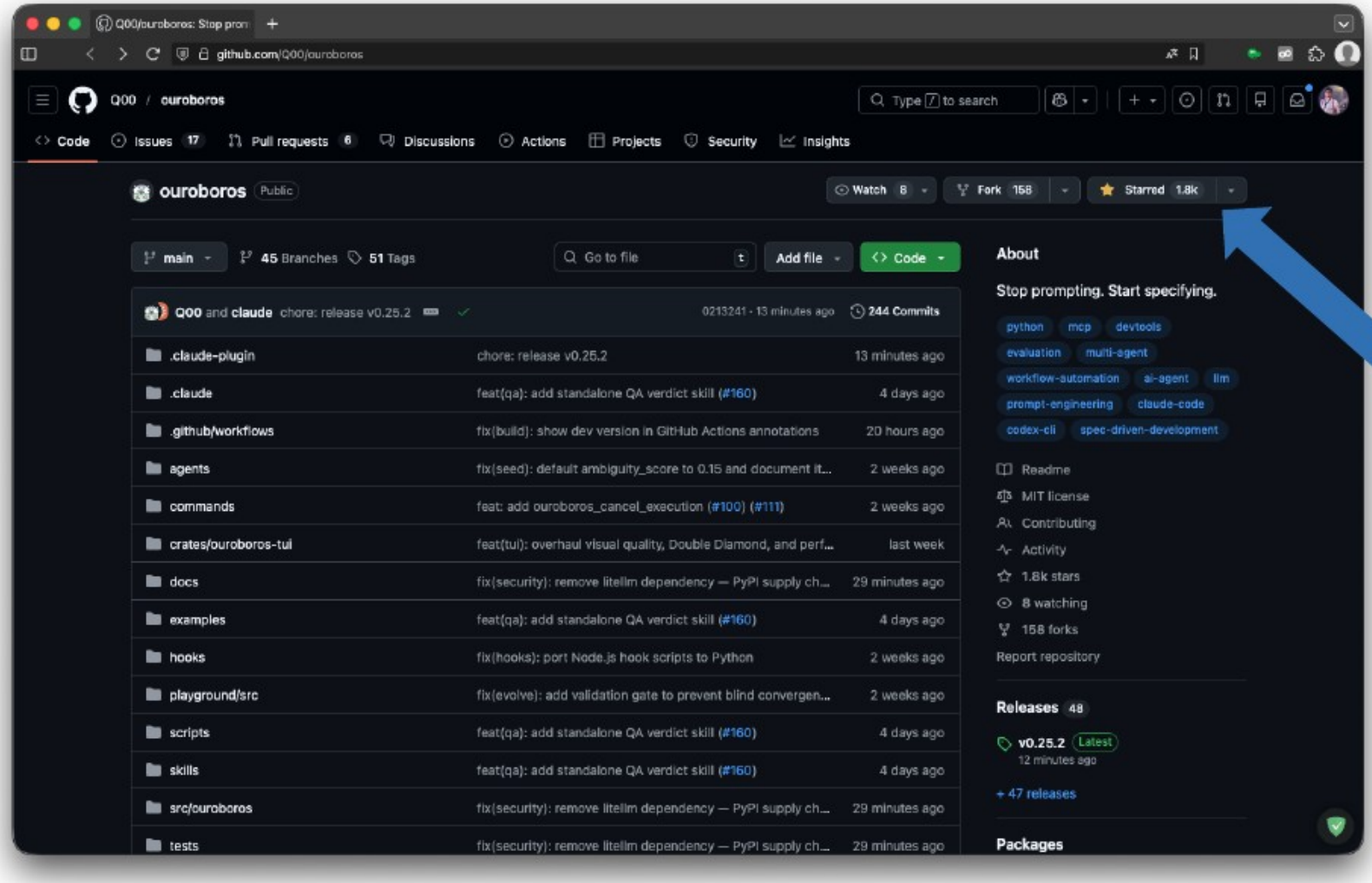


Your advantage, your success factor, your edge: Execution Speed

Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup

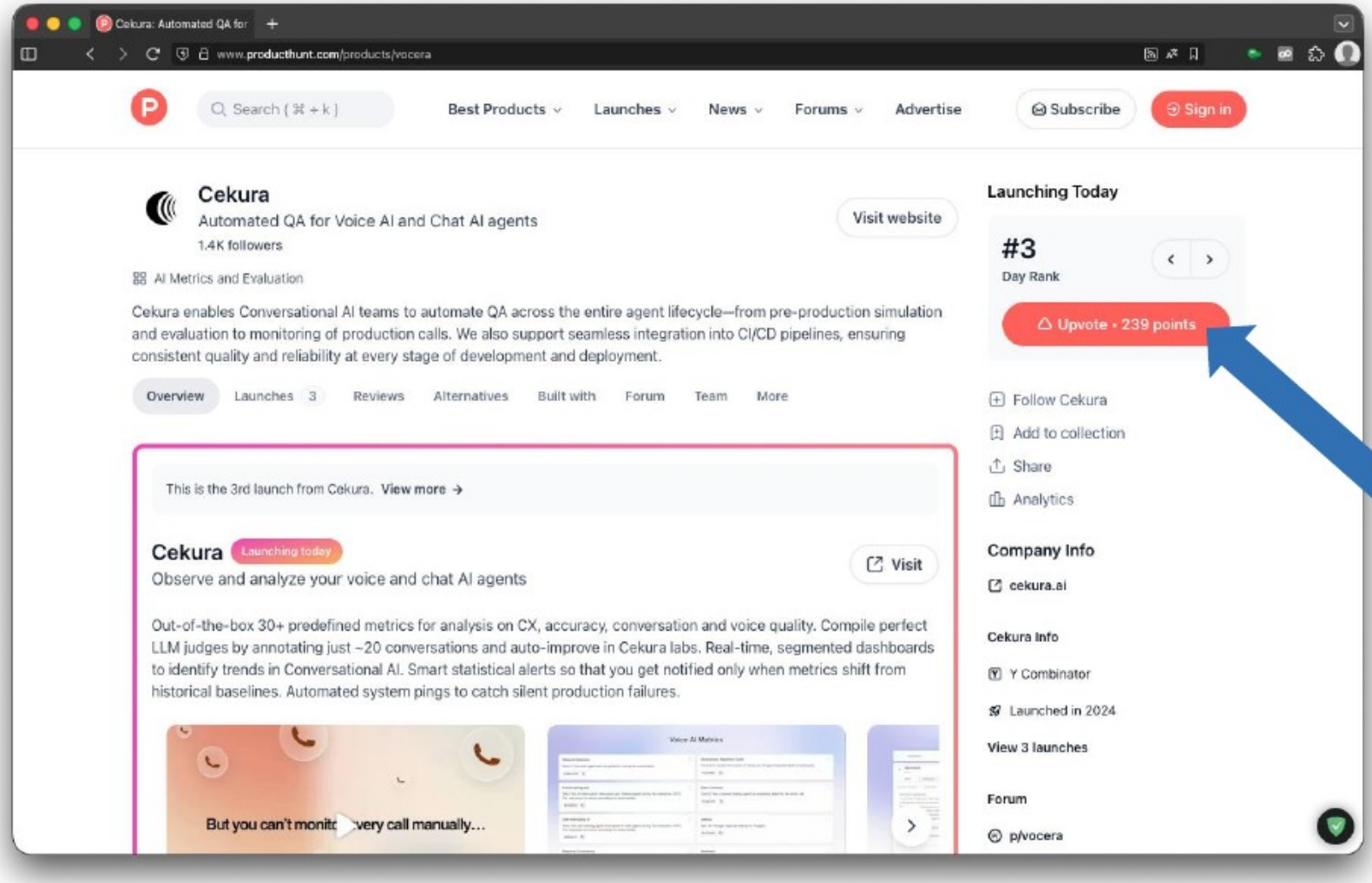


Github Stars as a proxy for tech validity



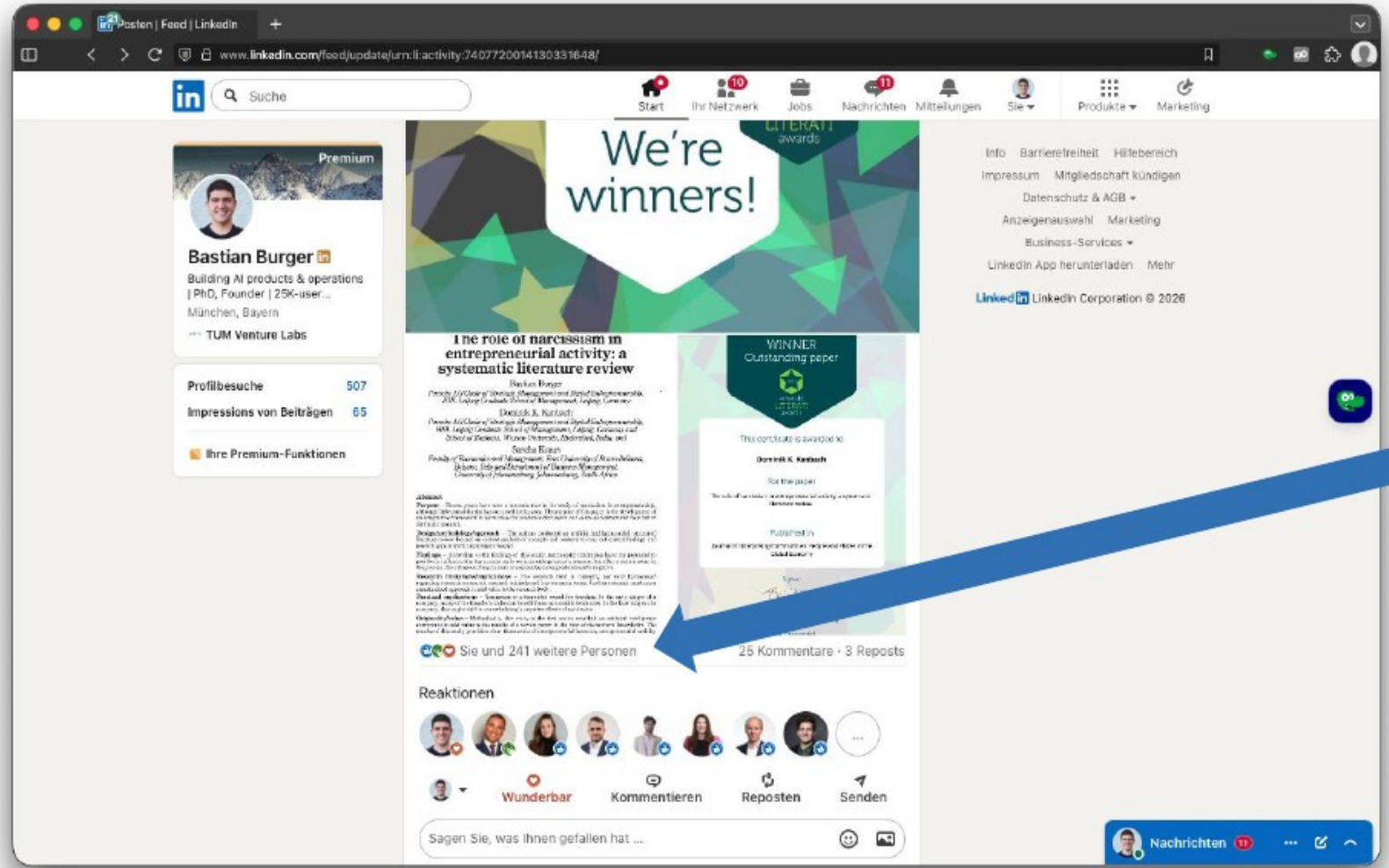
Gather Stars

ProductHunt Upvotes as a proxy for nice userflow



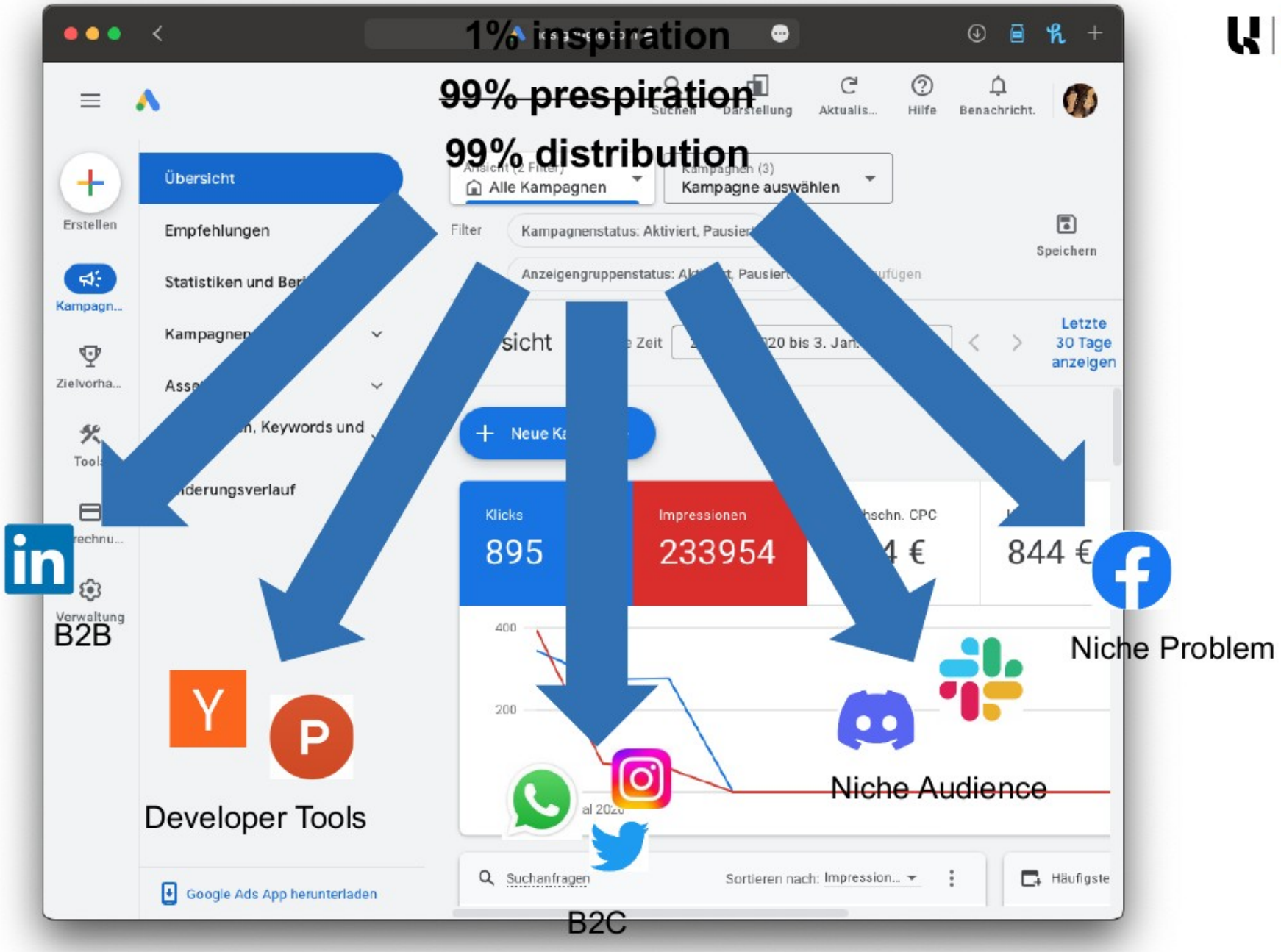
Collect Upvotes

Likes and Shares as a proxy for overall interest

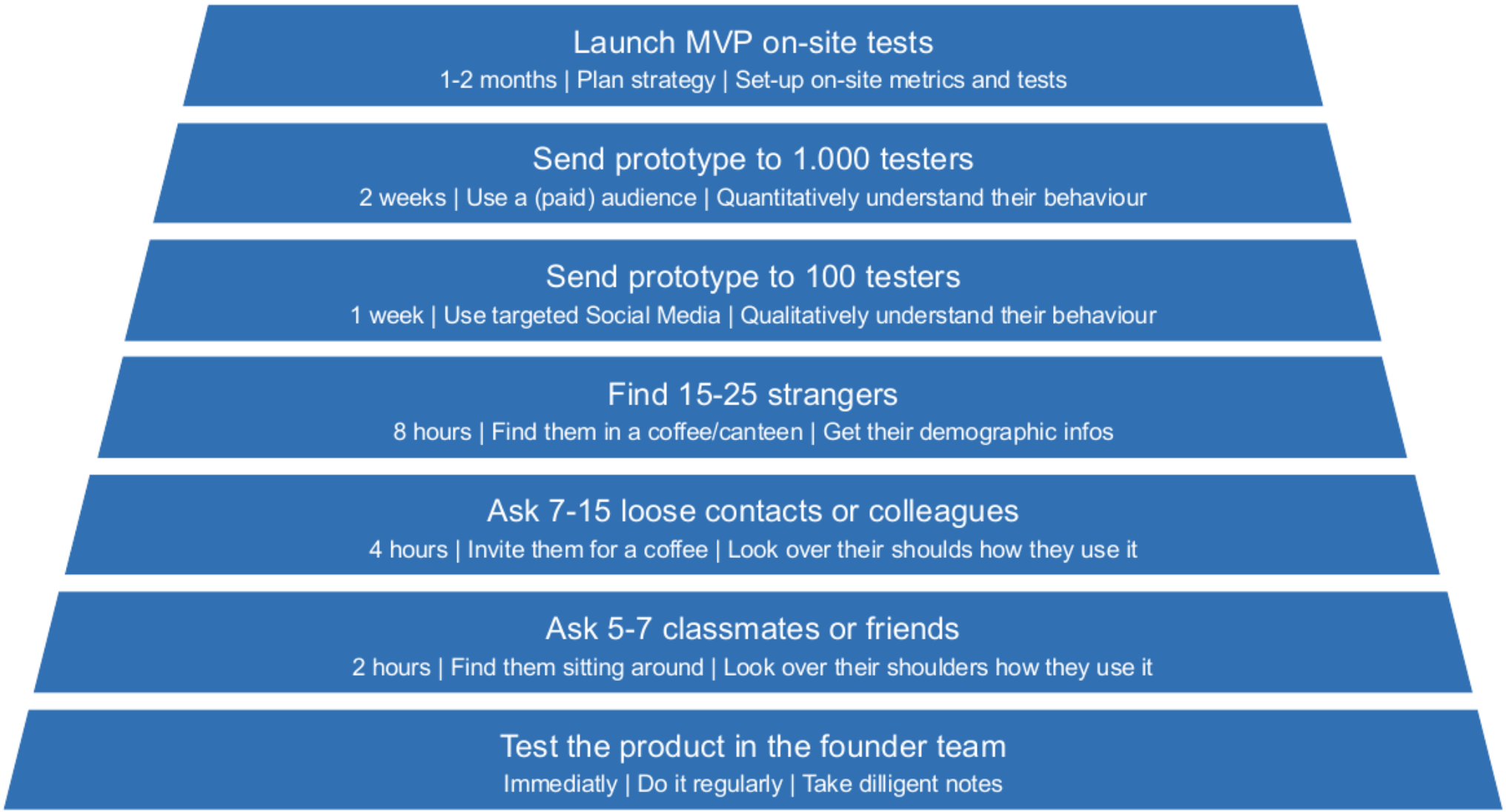


Growing a user community

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1% inspiration
99% prespiration
99% distribution
Übersicht
Empfehlungen
Erstellen
Kampagn...
Zielvorha...
Tools
Verwaltung
Alle Kampagnen
Kampagne auswählen
Filter
Speichern
Letzte 30 Tage anzeigen
Klicks
895
Impressionen
233954
844 €
400
200
Suchanfragen
Sortieren nach: Impression...
Häufigste
Google Ads App herunterladen
B2B
Developer Tools
Niche Problem
Niche Audience
B2C

Testing your prototype





Building an Audience



- **Build Engagement early:** Talk about what you do, find people who are interested
- **Create a brand:** Use social media with memable posts to collect a following
- **Create Virality:** What do people get for forwarding your asks
- **Collect all leads:** Always allow opportunities to leave email addresses
- **Reach out:** Use Newsletters and LinkedIn Mails to get to your users

Remember: Building begins in the problem space!
Your problem needs to be validated before the solution.

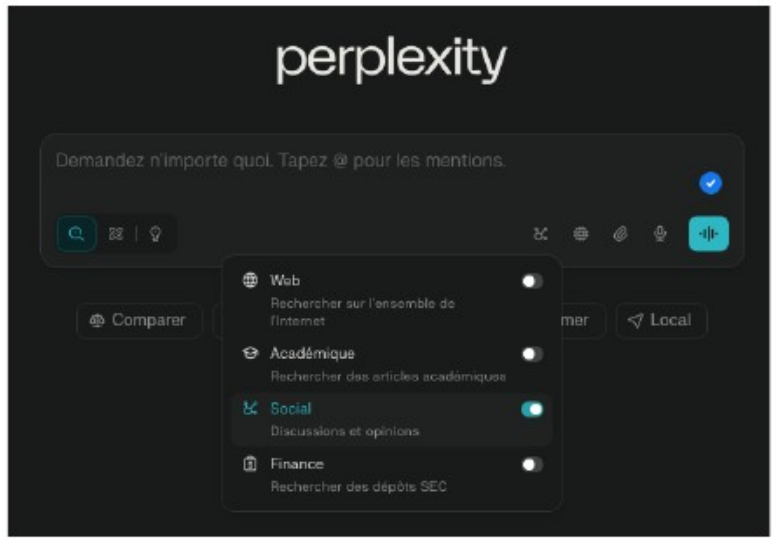
Strategies involving Social Media

Post Yourself:



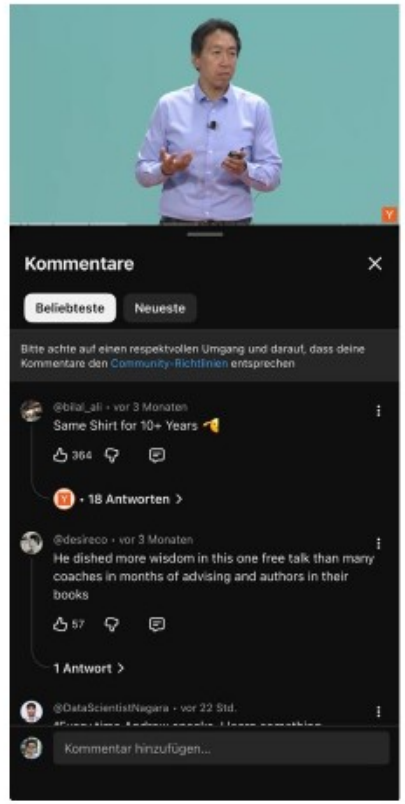
Scheduled job on your recent findings:
Create an engaging LinkedIn/… post

Find the current trend:



Use websearch to find relevant posts
in your area of interest

Like, Comment, & Subscribe:



AI not yet reliable… use your brain to interact
with existing content & communities

Building an Audience



Post regularly:

- What did you find out? What is interesting?
- What is helpful for your audience?
- What is counterintuitive/controversial?
- What open questions do you still have?

Who interacts with your content?

- Reach out to them for more interviews
- Encourage reposting
- Interact with all comments

What does your audience look like?

- Demography
- Matches your hypotheses?
- Why or why not?

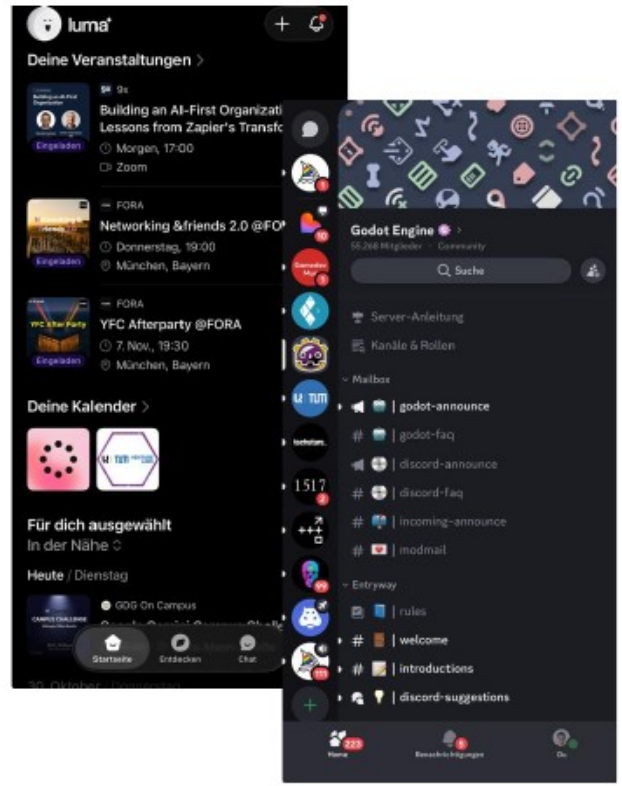
Audiences beyond Social Media

Specialist Media:



Use Perplexity or an AI search to find specialty media and then buy some of them

Online Communities:



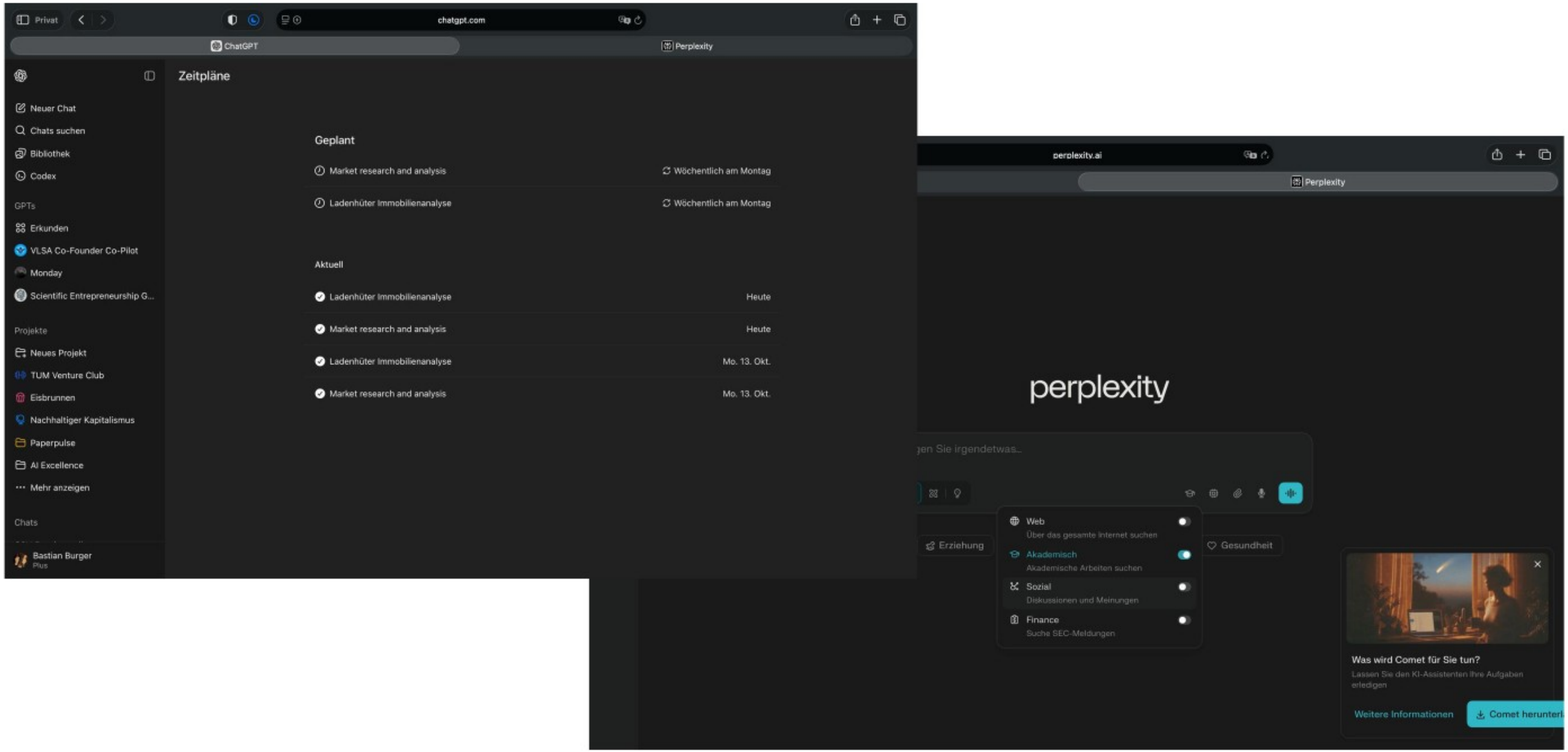
Use Agents (ChatGPT or MCP, schedules) to run on Luma, Eventbride, Meetup, Slack, Discord, WhatsApp

Offline Communities:



AI not yet reliable… use your brain to find hot-spots, offices, hangouts, etc.

It‘s a full-time job, let AI do the heavy lifting



Let‘s talk conversion (1/3)



Example Numbers:

740 **25** **1**

Conversion Rates:

3,4% **4%**

Industry Averages:

2-5% **1-3%**

How many IMPRESSIONS do you need for the desired number of Sign-Ups?

Get out of the building to get every day at least 7 interactions

Speed matters

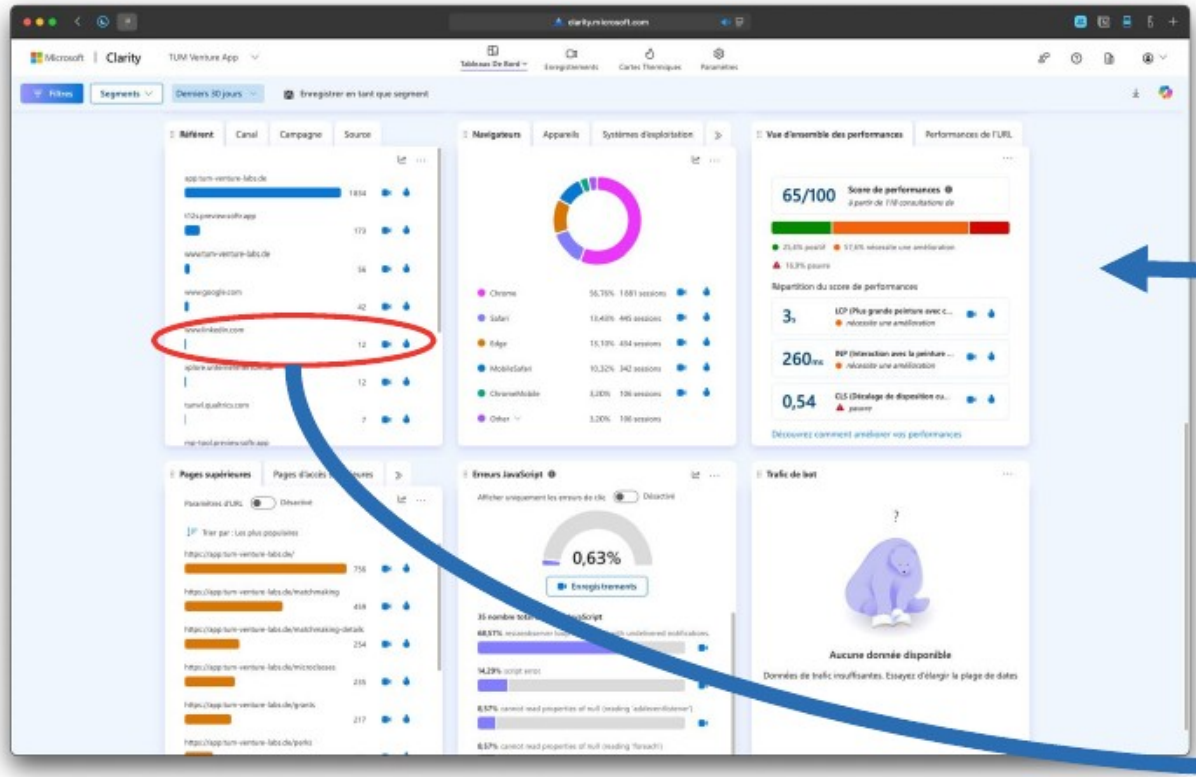
Get out of th to get every day at least ctions

10% CTR, 5% SUR, 7 daily signups:

Have **1.400 daily impressions!**



Double Down on what works



Meassure your success

2x the input

> 2x the outcome?



Nothing beats real

~~7~~ interaction~~s~~

WORKSHOP

JTBD Deep Dive + F.I.T. Assessment

60 minutes

VENTURE LABS

5 min

Interview Debrief

Share your top 3 findings from last week's interviews. What surprised you? What patterns emerged across the team?

15 min

Job Statement

Draft your JTBD statement: "When I [situation], I want to [motivation], so I can [outcome]." Refine until it's specific and real.

10 min

Peer Challenge

Swap JTBD statements with another team. Challenge hard: Is the situation specific enough? Is this a real job or a feature in disguise?

15 min

Pains & Gains Mapping

Silent brainstorm (3 min) → team share → prioritise top 3 pains and top 3 gains. Use interview quotes as evidence.

15 min

F.I.T. Scoring

Score your problem on Frequency, Intensity, and Trend. Back every score with real evidence from interviews. Present to class.

Deliverable: Completed JTBD Canvas + F.I.T. Score with evidence from interviews

STEP 1

Interview Debrief (5 min)

Before you build frameworks, ground yourself in what you actually heard.

1

What was the most surprising thing you heard?

Something you didn't expect. A pain you hadn't considered. A workaround that shocked you.

2

What patterns did you see across interviews?

Same words? Same frustrations? Same trigger moments? Or did every conversation go differently?

3

What made you doubt your original assumption?

If nothing did, you weren't listening hard enough — or you only talked to people who agree with you.

Bring your interview notes. You'll need direct quotes for the rest of this workshop.

STEP 2

Draft Your Job Statement (15 min)

People don't buy products. They hire them to make progress in their lives.

SITUATION	**When I...**	*Describe the specific trigger moment or context*
MOTIVATION	**I want to...**	*State the goal or desired progress*
OUTCOME	**So I can...**	*Articulate the expected result (functional + emotional)*

BAD

"When I need to be productive, I want a better tool, so I can work faster."

GOOD

"When I sit down Monday morning with 47 unread emails, I want to instantly see which 3 need action, so I can stop the anxiety of missing something critical."

Christensen, C. (2016). Competing Against Luck. Harper Business.

STEP 4

Pains & Gains Mapping (15 min)

3 min silent brainstorm → team share → prioritise top 3 pains + top 3 gains.

PAINS — What frustrates them?	GAINS — What delights them?
✗ Undesired outcomes they want to avoid	✓ Outcomes that make them successful
✗ Obstacles blocking their progress	✓ Functional benefits they expect
✗ Risks they're afraid of	✓ Emotional benefits they desire
✗ Current solutions that suck	✓ Social benefits (status, belonging)
✗ Emotional pains: frustration, embarrassment	✓ The 10x improvement they'd pay for

Rule: Every pain and gain must be backed by a real interview quote. No "I think" — only "they said."

STEP 5

F.I.T. Scoring (15 min)

Score your problem. Justify every number with evidence. Present to class.

F

FREQUENCY

How often does this problem occur?

1 = yearly 3 = monthly 5 = daily

I

INTENSITY

How painful is it when it happens?

1 = mild annoyance 3 = significant friction 5 = hair on fire

T

TREND

Is this problem growing or shrinking?

1 = declining 3 = stable 5 = exploding

Score 12–15: Full speed ahead | **Score 8–11:** Dig deeper | **Score < 8:** Reconsider the problem

REFLECTION

Problem Space Quality Check

S

SPECIFIC

Is your problem specific enough? Can you describe the exact trigger moment?

P

PAINFUL

Is it painful enough that people actively seek solutions and pay for them?

E

EVIDENCE

Do you have evidence from real conversations — not just assumptions or guesses?

Homework: 10–15 more interviews focused on your job statement. Try to DISPROVE your assumptions.

FRAMEWORK

Jobs-to-be-Done: "Hire" Products

> People don't buy products. They **HIRE** products to do a job.

⚙ Functional

What the product literally does for me

♥ Emotional

How it makes me feel

👥 Social

How others see me when I use it

The Drill Example

"I need a drill"

Surface request

→

"I need a hole"

Functional job

→

"I want to hang a picture"

Real goal

→

"I want to feel at home"

Emotional job

Christensen, C. (2016). Competing Against Luck. Harper Business.

Get out of the building to get every day at least 7 interactions

Reflection: Pain and Gain

What will be most uncomfortable for you /out of your comfort zone?



What will give you the biggest improvement and why?



Assignment for home-work

1. Define the JTBD for your problem space
2. Test and iterate with at least 7 real interactions per week
3. Decide on the validation you are looking for and set up channels
4. Publish what you are working on and monitor the interest

Thank You!

A joint initiative by